Manufactured Majorities

The Impact of the First-Past-The-Post Electoral System on the Quality of Voters' Representation in the United Kingdom and Canada

Yusuf ACET

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For this assessment, I have chosen to study the First-Past-The-Post (FPTP) electoral system and its impact on representation. To do so, I study two countries that use FPTP: the United Kingdom and Canada. I end the paper with a recommendation for institutional reform intended to address the problem.

Before turning to the cases of Canada and the United Kingdom, I explain what this system is and what problems it raises.

The First-Past-The-Post system, sometimes called the Winner-Takes-All system, is a majoritarian system that produces a distribution of seats which is not proportional to the votes cast. In a single-member district, the candidate who receives the most votes, even without an absolute majority, wins the seat. Following "Duverger's law", this system tends to produce a two-party system in which two parties dominate electoral competition and one of them can easily obtain a majority of seats.[1] This tendency results from a mechanical effect (small parties rarely win seats) and a psychological effect (supporters of small parties anticipate this and may vote strategically for one of the main contenders).[2] However, FPTP does not always give the majority of seats to a party that received a majority of the votes (50% + 1); in fact, single-party majorities are usually "manufactured" from a plurality of the vote. This is the main consequence for representation that I analyse here. FPTP is also often associated with lower turnout than proportional representation, although comparative research shows that this effect is modest and varies across regions of the world.[3] The drawing of electoral boundaries is another key issue under FPTP, because it can lead to gerrymandering or to unequal district populations.[4] Finally, the system can favour regionalist and separatist parties whose votes are geographically concentrated.[5]

The United Kingdom

The UK general election of June 2017 elected the 650 members of the House of Commons.[6] The Conservatives received 42.4% of the votes (13,636,684) across the country, while Labour received 40.0% (12,877,858). Turnout was 68.8%. The Conservatives won 317 seats and Labour 262. The Liberal Democrats received 7.4% of the votes (2,371,861) and the Scottish National Party (SNP) 3.0% (977,568). The key issue in these cases is the proportionality of the seat share: the SNP won 35 seats with 3.0% of the votes, while the Liberal Democrats won only 12 seats with a larger share of the votes (7.4%). Likewise, the Conservatives received 42.4% of the votes but obtained 48.8% of the seats. The Conservatives and the SNP were therefore over-represented (the SNP had 5.4% of the seats with only 3.0% of the votes), while the Liberal Democrats were under-represented (7.4% of the votes but only 1.8% of the seats). Labour's seat share (40.3%) was very close to its vote share.

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[1] Maurice Duverger, *Les partis politiques* (Paris : Armand Colin, 1951); Gary W. Cox, *Making Votes Count: Strategic Coordination in the World's Electoral Systems* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997).

[2] André Blais and Arianna Degan, « L'étude empirique du vote stratégique », *L'Actualité économique* 93, no. 1-2 (2017): 47–78.

[3] André Blais and R. Kenneth Carty, "Does Proportional Representation Foster Voter Turnout?," *European Journal of Political Research* 18, no. 2 (1990): 167–181; André Blais, "What Affects Voter Turnout?," *Annual Review of Political Science* 9 (2006): 111–125.

[4] Paul E. J. Thomas, Peter John Loewen and Michael K. MacKenzie, "Fair Isn't Always Equal: Constituency Population and the Quality of Representation in Canada," *Canadian Journal of Political Science / Revue canadienne de science politique* 46, no. 2 (2013): 273–293.

[5] Florence Faucher, « Le système électoral britannique », in *Le mode de scrutin fait-il l'élection ?*, ed. Pascal Delwit and Jean-Michel De Waele (Bruxelles : Éditions de l'Université de Bruxelles, 2000), 50–67.

[6] Vyara Apostolova et al., *General Election 2017: Results and Analysis*, Briefing Paper CBP-7979 (London: House of Commons Library, 2018).

The most recent general election, held on 4 July 2024, shows that this distortion can become much larger. Labour won 411 seats (63.2%) with only 33.7% of the votes. The Conservatives won 121 seats (18.6%) with 23.7% of the votes, and the Liberal Democrats 72 seats (11.1%) with 12.2%. By contrast, Reform UK won only 5 seats (0.8%) with 14.3% of the votes, and the Greens 4 seats (0.6%) with 6.7%. Turnout fell to 59.9%.[7] Measured with the Gallagher least-squares index, the 2024 election was the most disproportionate in British history (23.6, against a previous record of 20.6 in 1983).[8] Moreover, 85% of MPs (554 of 650) were elected with less than 50% of the vote in their constituency, and 41% (266) with less than 40%.[9]

We can therefore say that the quality of voters' representation is affected, because many voters, and often the majority of voters in a district, vote for candidates who will not sit in Parliament.

Canada

For Canada, I first analyse the 2015 federal election, which, as in the UK, elected the members of the House of Commons. In this case, the gap between seat share and vote share is larger than in the UK in 2017. The House of Commons then had 338 seats. The Liberal Party received 39.5% of the votes but won 184 of the 338 seats, which gave it a majority (170 seats were needed, i.e. 50% + 1) and allowed it to govern without the support of another party. The Conservative Party received 31.9% of the votes but only 99 seats (29.3% of the seats). The New Democratic Party (NDP) and the *Bloc Québécois* (BQ) were both under-represented: the NDP received 19.7% of the votes but only 44 seats (13.0%), and the BQ 4.7% of the votes but only 10 seats (3.0%).[10] The Liberal Party was thus advantaged: with 39.5% of the votes, it obtained 54.4% of the seats, a bonus of about 15 percentage points. The NDP and the BQ were disadvantaged, losing about 6.7 and 1.7 percentage points respectively. Again, we can see that FPTP has an impact on the quality of voters' representation.

These additional seats did not come from nowhere: they come from districts in which the Liberal Party won with a plurality (sometimes around 30% to 35% of the votes) rather than a majority.

In many districts, therefore, the seat is won by a candidate supported by a minority of voters, which is a paradox of the majoritarian system. For instance, in the district of *Montmagny–L'Islet–Kamouraska–Rivière-du-Loup*, the Conservative candidate won with only 29.0% of the votes, 272 votes ahead of the Liberal candidate (28.4%).[11] This raises a problem of representativeness and legitimacy: 71% of the voters in this district supported another candidate. This voting system does not, however, have only "negative" effects. It is often credited with producing stable, accountable and strong single-party governments.[12]

The more recent elections confirm this pattern, but also show that its intensity varies with the structure of competition. In 2019 and 2021, the Liberal Party formed minority governments while

[7] House of Commons Library, *General Election 2024 Results*, Research Briefing CBP-10009 (London: House of Commons Library, 2024, updated 2026), https://commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/cbp-10009/; Electoral Reform Society, *A System Out of Step: The 2024 General Election* (London: Electoral Reform Society, 2024), 2, 7, 15, 39. The Speaker is excluded from Labour's total in the ERS figures.
[8] Electoral Reform Society, *A System Out of Step*, 9. On the index itself, see Michael Gallagher, "Proportionality, Disproportionality and Electoral Systems," *Electoral Studies* 10, no. 1 (1991): 33–51.
[9] Electoral Reform Society, *A System Out of Step*, 12.
[10] Elections Canada, *Forty-Second General Election 2015: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada). Seat shares are my own calculation (seats/338).
[11] « Canada Votes 2015 », CBC News, accessed December 14, 2018, https://www.cbc.ca/includes/federalelection/dashboard/; Elections Canada, *Forty-Second General Election 2015: Official Voting Results*.
[12] Pascal Delwit, *Introduction à la science politique* (Bruxelles : Éditions de l'Université de Bruxelles, 2013), 173.

receiving fewer votes than the Conservatives (33.1% against 34.3% in 2019; 32.6% against 33.7% in 2021).[13] In the federal election of 28 April 2025, the House of Commons had 343 seats following redistribution. The Liberals won 169 seats (49.3%) with 43.8% of the votes and the Conservatives 144 seats (42.0%) with 41.3%, while the NDP obtained only 7 seats (2.0%) with 6.3% of the votes, exactly the same vote share as the Bloc Québécois, which won 22 seats (6.4%) thanks to the concentration of its vote in Quebec.[14] Because the two main parties attracted together 85% of the votes, the overall disproportionality was lower than in previous elections (a Gallagher index of about 5, against about 12 in 2015 and 2019, according to my own calculation from the official results), but the distortion between the NDP and the BQ shows that geography, rather than the number of votes, determines representation under FPTP.[15]

To sum up, we have seen that in the UK and Canada the electoral system has an important impact on representation. There is clearly a problem of representativeness in the First-Past-The-Post system. Some voters are poorly represented (those who vote for a losing candidate are represented by a winner they did not vote for), and in many districts the seat is won by a candidate supported by a minority of voters. In the next section, I therefore propose an institutional reform intended to improve voters' representation. My objective here is only to improve the quality of representation, not to assess the stability of the regime or the consequences for governments.

Recommendation

The First-Past-The-Post system has advantages and disadvantages, but its main disadvantage is that it does not produce a proportional representation of voters. Furthermore, it can lead to a situation in which a party governs alone with a minority of the votes. Therefore, in order to obtain a more proportional relationship between votes and seats, I propose the following recommendation. To be clear, institutional reforms in the United Kingdom and in Canada cannot be identical, but since both countries use the same electoral system, the reform I propose concerns this system.

The proportional system

In a proportional system, the main objective is to obtain an assembly whose composition is as close as possible to the distribution of the votes.[16] We could therefore replace the majoritarian system with a proportional one. Most proportional systems are list systems: each party presents a list of candidates in each district, and voters vote for a list rather than for an individual candidate.

In the case of the UK and Canada, each party could present a list in every district. Voters would choose a list, and one or several of its candidates would be elected depending on the votes received. Such a reform would allow more parties, including small ones, to enter Parliament and would of course improve the representation of voters. However, it raises a practical problem. If the current districts are kept and each elects several representatives, the size of the assembly would increase considerably: the House of Commons currently has 343 members in Canada and 650 in the UK, and multiplying this number by three or four would hardly be workable. If, on the other hand, the boundaries are redrawn to create larger multi-member districts, the proximity between

[13] Elections Canada, *Forty-Third General Election 2019: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada); Elections Canada, *Forty-Fourth General Election 2021: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada).
[14] Elections Canada, *Forty-Fifth General Election 2025: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada), tables 7 and 8, https://elections.ca/res/rep/off/ovrGE45/62/table8E.html. Seat shares are my own calculation (seats/343).
[15] Author's calculation of the Gallagher least-squares index from the official results cited in notes 10, 13 and 14, following Gallagher, "Proportionality, Disproportionality and Electoral Systems."
[16] Delwit, *Introduction à la science politique*, 175.

representatives and voters would be weakened, since each representative would cover a larger territory.[17]

Comparative research suggests a way out of this dilemma. Carey and Hix show that proportional systems with low-to-moderate district magnitudes (relatively small multi-member districts) achieve most of the benefits of proportional representation in terms of representativeness, while limiting party fragmentation and preserving accountability; they call this the electoral "sweet spot".[18] Redrawing boundaries to create such districts therefore seems to be the best solution. This is consistent with the recommendation of the Canadian House of Commons Special Committee on Electoral Reform, which in 2016 advised the government to design a proportional system with a Gallagher index of 5 or less while maintaining a local link between voters and their MP, and to submit it to a referendum.[19] At the same time, we could encourage the participation of voters in decision-making through tools of direct democracy, such as referendums. Finally, the redrawing of boundaries should remain in the hands of independent bodies, as it already is in both countries, where non-partisan boundary commissions draw the districts,[20] in order to ensure neutrality and a good knowledge of the reality on the ground.

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[17] Faucher, « Le système électoral britannique », 50–67.
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[19] House of Commons of Canada, Special Committee on Electoral Reform, *Strengthening Democracy in Canada: Principles, Process and Public Engagement for Electoral Reform*, Third Report (Ottawa, December 2016). The government abandoned the reform in February 2017: "Opposition Accuses Trudeau of 'Betrayal' as Liberals Abandon Promise of Electoral Reform," CBC News, February 1, 2017, https://www.cbc.ca/1.3961736.
[20] In Canada, under the *Electoral Boundaries Readjustment Act* (R.S.C. 1985, c. E-3); in the UK, under the *Parliamentary Constituencies Act 1986*. See also Thomas, Loewen and MacKenzie, "Fair Isn't Always Equal," 273–293.

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